HILCHOT SHABBAT

Should You Borrow Money to Honour Shabbat?

Given Thursday 12 November 2026 · Hilchot Shabbat | Siman 242

Sefer: Shulhan Arukh, Orah Hayim, Hilchot Shabbat **Siman:** 242, seif 1 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Thursday Hilchot Shabbat class, Thursday 27 April 2023

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Starting Hilchot Shabbat in order

This class opened a new cycle: going through Hilchot Shabbat in the Shulhan Arukh in order, over the coming year. The Mishnah Berurah writes in his introduction how important it is to learn these laws, because one who does not learn them forgets them and ends up not keeping Shabbat properly. Revising Hilchot Shabbat is something everyone needs.

Siman 242 is one of the easiest chapters, with a single paragraph: we must be careful about the honour and delight of Shabbat.

Oneg Shabbat: what it is and where it comes from

Oneg Shabbat literally means delighting in Shabbat: enjoying it with good food, rest and sleep, and whatever a person enjoys.

Is it from the Torah? The source is the pasuk we Sefaradim say every Shabbat in Kiddush, "VeKarata LaShabbat Oneg", "you shall call Shabbat a delight". From this the Ramban and others learn that Oneg Shabbat is a misvah from the Torah, so everything one does to honour and enjoy Shabbat is a Torah misvah. Others hold it is rabbinic. Either way it is an important misvah.

Oneg is not Simhah. The Rabbi contrasted Shabbat with Yom Tov: - On Yom Tov there is a misvah of Simhah, and Hazal said "there is no Simhah except with meat and wine". One should make the effort to have meat and wine on Yom Tov, unless it really makes a person unhappy. - On Shabbat the misvah is Oneg, which means whatever you personally enjoy. The Gemara mentions large fish, heads of garlic and cabbage, the delicacies of their day. If your delight is pizza, "go for it". That would not be appropriate on Yom Tov, but is absolutely fine on Shabbat.

Three statements about spending on Shabbat

The Gemara makes three statements that seem to contradict each other:

1. A person should spend as much as possible for Shabbat.
2. Even something small, like a small fish, fulfils the misvah.
3. "Make your Shabbat like a weekday rather than depend on other people", that is, rather than take charity.

The reconciliation: - **If you can afford it**, spend as much as possible on Shabbat. - **If you are very tight but not yet taking charity**, make do with something small. Every day a person has two meals; what is special about Shabbat is a third meal and a special dish. If you only have enough for two simple meals, do not ask for charity to get the third meal and the fish. Bread and a little herring is enough. - **If you have nothing**, you take charity, and those who give charity must give you all three meals and the fish. Once they are giving, they give properly. The laws of charity even say that a person who was used to having duck every Friday night and lost his money should be given duck.

Wine for Kiddush is a separate matter. It is not for enjoyment but for the misvah, so one may ask for it.

The Shulhan Arukh adds that even a person who lives on others should, if he has a little of his own, do his best to honour Shabbat. Therefore a person should be frugal during the week in order to have enough for Shabbat. Do not buy delicacies during the week and then find on Friday that there is nothing left for the Shabbat fish.

He added some customs from the Mishnah Berurah: it is good to have two dishes at each meal, and the Kabbalists speak of having fish at all three meals, unless you do not like fish.

The worker comes first

If you have very little money on Friday and a worker comes to be paid for work finished that day, the Biur Halacha rules that you must pay him, to fulfil "pay him on the same day" (which, the Rabbi noted, was in that week's parashah). Paying a worker on time is a Torah positive and negative commandment; Oneg Shabbat is at most a positive commandment, and according to many only rabbinic. If he agrees to be paid next week, that is also fine.

Another way out: if you sent something to be repaired or cleaned and no date was agreed, you are not obliged to take it back now. You may tell him you will collect it later, and then you pay when you take it. If a date was agreed, you must keep to it.

Someone objected that this seems unfair to the craftsman. The Rabbi answered that the obligation to pay comes when you receive the work. When you hire someone to come and paint your house, you know he is coming and you have the money ready. When no time was agreed, you decide when to collect.

Borrowing for Shabbat

The Mishnah Berurah says that the ruling "make do with little" applies only when you have nothing to borrow against. If you can borrow, you should borrow so as not to lose Oneg Shabbat, as the Gemara says in the name of HaKadosh Barukh Hu: "My children, borrow on My account and I will repay."

The Rabbi called this "very problematic" and stressed the Mishnah Berurah's condition: you should only borrow if you know how you will pay it back. Use common sense.

"Never ever borrow without knowing how you're going to pay back."

He warned against the credit card habit of spending now and worrying later. Borrowing for Shabbat is also not a blank cheque to buy anything you like; it is for what you need to enjoy

Shabbat. If your salary comes at the end of the month and you are short this month, you may put Shabbat shopping on the card.

Asked whether it is better to have two lavish meals or three ordinary ones, he answered: three meals is definitely better.

Ezra's enactment: washing clothes on Thursday

The Shulhan Arukh says Ezra enacted that clothes be washed on Thursday for the honour of Shabbat (one of the ten enactments of Ezra in Bava Kamma). There are two ways to understand it: - **Positive:** you must wash your clothes for Shabbat, and do it on Thursday because Friday is busy. - **Negative:** there is no obligation to wash, but if you wash, do not do it on Friday.

The Mishnah Berurah in the Shaar HaSiyun takes it as positive. It refers to garments next to the body that get sweaty, such as a shirt or vest. So you need a clean shirt for Shabbat; a jacket or suit does not need cleaning every week.

Baking hallah on Friday

The Rema says it is customary to bake hallah on Friday for Shabbat. The Rabbi explained that the misvah here is really taking hallah, the separation of dough. Havah corrupted Adam, "the hallah of the world", and women rectify this by separating hallah, which is why it is done on Friday. The Biur Halacha complained, already over a hundred years ago, that women were buying bread from the baker instead of baking.

The Rabbi said this must be balanced today, when many women work. There are two elements: preparing yourself for Shabbat, and taking hallah. If a woman has time, how wonderful to bake on Friday, or on Thursday if not. But it is a custom and a nice thing; "you don't have to drive yourself mad over it".

The Rema also brings a custom to eat a pashtida, a pastry with meat inside, on Friday night, in memory of the man, covered with dew above and below. Rabbi Benvenisti, Chief Rabbi of Izmir, mentions it, and Gibraltarians still have a similar dish.

Practical summary

- Oneg Shabbat means enjoying Shabbat with what you personally like; Yom Tov specifically calls for meat and wine.
- If you can afford it, spend generously on Shabbat; be frugal in the week so there is enough for Shabbat.
- If you are tight, make do with something small rather than ask for charity; if you have nothing, take charity for all three meals.
- Borrow for Shabbat only when you know how you will repay.
- Pay a worker on time before spending on Shabbat food, unless he agrees to wait.
- Wear a clean shirt for Shabbat; baking and taking hallah on Friday is a lovely custom, not a burden.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/EH8XQ3Mgy5Y · More shiurim: rabbikada.com